Teach Us to Pray

Matthew 6:5-15 (KJV)

Scripture

Matthew 6:5-15

5 And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites are: for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corners of the streets, that they may be seen of men. Verily I say unto you, They have their reward. 6 But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly. 7 But when ye pray, use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do: for they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking. 8 Be not ye therefore like unto them: for your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him. 9 After this manner therefore pray ye: Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. 10 Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven. 11 Give us this day our daily bread. 12 And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. 13 And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen. 14 For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: 15 But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.

Outline

1. Pray to your Father, not to an audience

The hypocrites prayed to be _____ of men.

Jesus says to pray to your _____ which is in secret.

Read: Matthew 6:5-6; Mark 1:35; Psalm 62:8

2. Pray simply, trusting a Father who knows

God does not need many words, because he already _____ what we need.

Prayer is not to inform God but to change our _____.

Read: Matthew 6:7-8; Luke 11:11-13; Philippians 4:6-7

3. Pray the pattern Jesus gave: God first, then our needs

The Lord's Prayer begins with God's name, kingdom, and _____.

Asking for daily bread reminds us that we _____ on God every day.

Read: Matthew 6:9-13; Luke 11:1-4; 1 John 5:14

Discussion questions

1. Why is praying "to be seen" so tempting, even in church?

2. If God already knows what we need, why pray at all?

3. Which part of the Lord's Prayer do you find easiest to pray, and which hardest?

4. How could the order of the Lord's Prayer (God first, then our needs) change your own prayers this week?

This week

Choose a "closet" this week: a quiet place and a set time, even five minutes. Shut the door, and pray the Lord's Prayer slowly, one line at a time. After each line, add your own words about what that line means for you today.